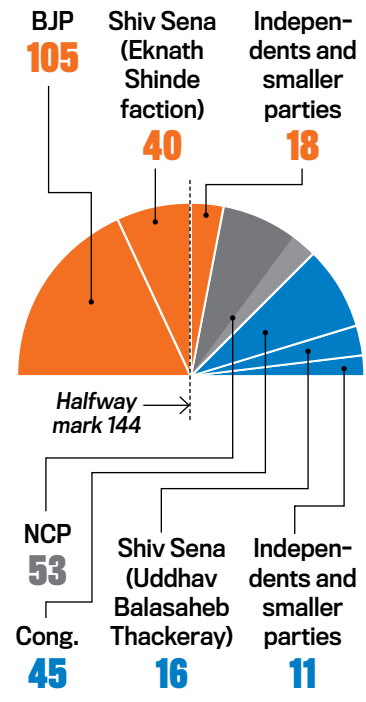


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Ajit Pawar's NCP faction claims 40 MLAs, which will shrink the opposition space further

Total seats: **288**



Likely strength of Ajit Pawar and Sharad Pawar factions

AS political manoeuvres go, this was a masterstroke. Just a year after it broke the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) government and formed one of its own with Eknath Shinde's band of 39 Shiv Sena MLAs, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has struck again, this time weaning away leader of the opposition Ajit Pawar and leaving the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) in disarray.

On July 2, Ajit Pawar was sworn in as Maharashtra's second deputy chief minister (the BJP's Devendra Fadnavis being the other) along with eight colleagues from the NCP. The move is aimed at shoring up support for the BJP, and comes at a time when Ajit's uncle and NCP president Sharad Pawar is part of the efforts to forge a nationwide opposition against the saffron party for the 2024 general election. In a replay of Shinde's rebellion, the rebel faction now claims to be the 'official NCP'. The two groups have also moved the Election Commission of India (ECI) claiming to be the official party. The rival camp has also replaced Pawar Sr with Ajit as the national president. The outcome of this battle in the ECI will determine who gets the NCP's official name and clock symbol. "This is a psychological victory for sure; now the fight is with 'Congress-plus', rather than the MVA alliance," says a top BJP leader in New Delhi who monitors Maharashtra closely.

Senior BJP leaders admit splitting the NCP was their Plan B since the experiment with doing the same to the Shiv Sena has not gone as planned. "Contrary to speculation, the defection was not triggered to bolster our numbers in the state assembly, where we already have a comfortable majority. This is to strengthen our chances in the Lok Sabha election. The NCP leaders are local satraps with a captive